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Volume XXXIV Number 49; For the week
December 1-7, 2009, released on November 30

• Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23315801-4; Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi
• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301; Phone: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from ISDN/MTNL lines); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and Patiala; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080; e-mail: ircvcr@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-24444423-6; Fax: 24444358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Connaught House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor, Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Panel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton House, T-4, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 96-A, Dr. Radhakrishna Salai, 2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phone: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177
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From the editor-in-chief

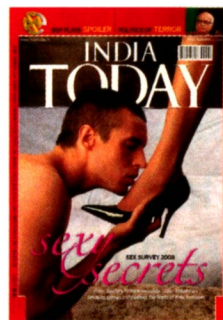
Back in 2003 when INDIA TODAY decided to conduct the country's first comprehensive survey on sex and sexual attitudes, we were, I remember, quite apprehensive. Questioners from the market research agency we had commissioned were met with open hostility and women refused to answer questions unless male members of the household were present. The response from our readers was quite the opposite and convinced us to make it an annual issue. This is the seventh in the series which, in a sense, mirrors the changes in Indian society that have come with rapid economic growth which has given women greater independence, rapid urbanisation and the wired global world we live in which has given everyone access to information on any subject under the sun, including sex.

Our first survey was pathbreaking in that it was the first all-woman survey on sexuality. The aim was to understand an average Indian female's sexual preferences and showed the first stirrings of independence with a majority of women being quite vocal and expressive about their sexual desires. In 2004, the survey polled men, married and unmarried, on the same subject. The survey also added an element of anonymity in the poll so that respondents would be less inhibited. While the broad trend was similar in terms of conservatism, the survey did reveal much about male fantasies and preferences. The ultimate fantasy was Aishwarya Rai under a waterfall, very Bollywood, very safe. The big change in attitude came during our 2005 survey. There was less hypocrisy and conservatism about sex, partly fuelled by the tv explosion with serials breaking new ground in terms of sexual subject matter. One in four unmarried urban women confessed to having had sex, and the demands they were making in their relationship revealed a brave new woman with a new assertiveness on sexual matters.

We then surveyed India's unmarried male youth in 2006, between the ages of 16 and 25. Once again, the results were surprising in that they showed a certain degree of confusion and lack of sexual experience and confidence. 2008 was again a different story, involving couples aged between 21 and 50. It was intended to study the status of sex and marriage and the taboos that form part of the secret life of Indians. Here was a greater openness about sexual matters than previous surveys and showed a more adventurous and also darker side to India's silent sexual revolution.

The 2009 survey is on sexual fantasies and the key findings show continuity with our last year's survey, as men and women step further out of the closet. There are, however, some disturbing trends in this year's findings: of the men who fantasise about role playing, a substantial percentage imagine raping their partner, which our analysts say may well be the male backlash to the changes in the position of women in society. That apart, as one of our columnists says, though sex within marriage may not be the start of a great dialogue between the sexes, at least it has put them on the road to acknowledging physical pleasure. It's a hopeful beginning.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR DECEMBER
2008 COVER